ARAB NOMAD FEST · TAGHAZOUT · 2026

The Five Senses *Formula™*

by Nadia Minds



BEFORE I INTRODUCE MYSELF

Let’s do a *Five Senses Check-In.*

Scan the QR code, put your name and email, and answer honestly. Go fast, with your gut. You have two minutes.



thefivesensesformula.com/checkin3

YOUR RESULTS

Tell me *what came out.*



Touch
how you move



Smell
how you breathe



Taste
how you fuel



Sound
what you let in



Sight
light and screens

regulated strained dysregulated (11 out of 15 or more)

Hands up: which sense came out the highest?

NOW, WHO I AM

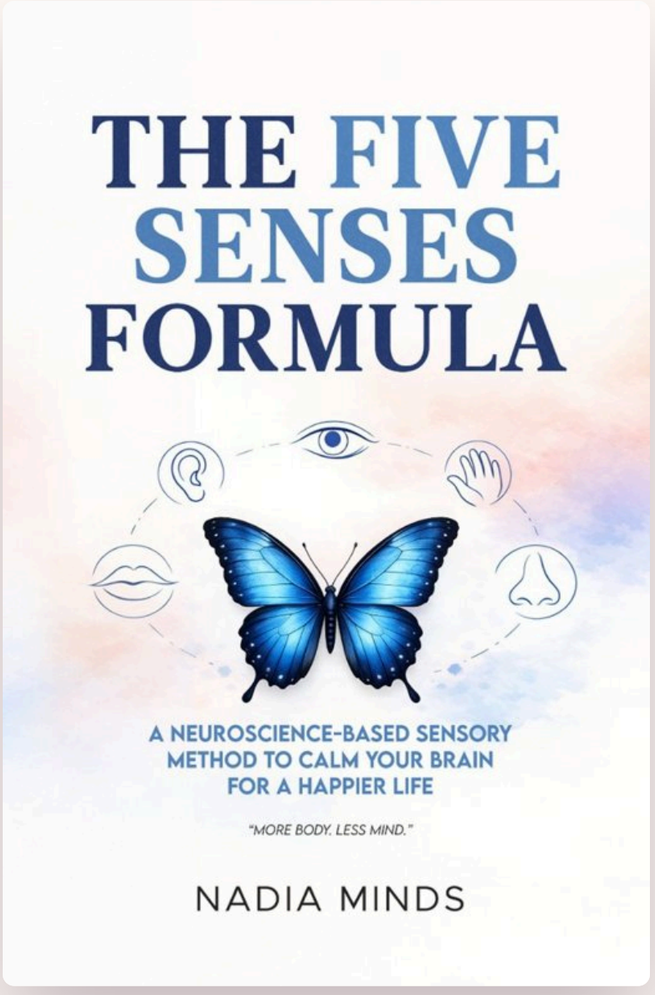
I am *Nadia.*

🧠 **ADHD coach.** Diagnosed at 26, travelling full time.

📱 **40K followers** on Instagram, @nadiaminds.

🔬 **Independent neuroscience researcher.** The studies behind my book.

📖 **Author** of The Five Senses Formula: **over 1,500 copies sold.**



WHAT THE CHECK-IN MEASURED

Five senses, *one system.*

Every score you gave was a reading of the same thing: how loud your nervous system is running right now. The senses are the way in, so they are also the way to read it.



TO EXPLAIN WHAT THAT MEANS

I use one picture: a song and a radio.

THE PICTURE TO REMEMBER

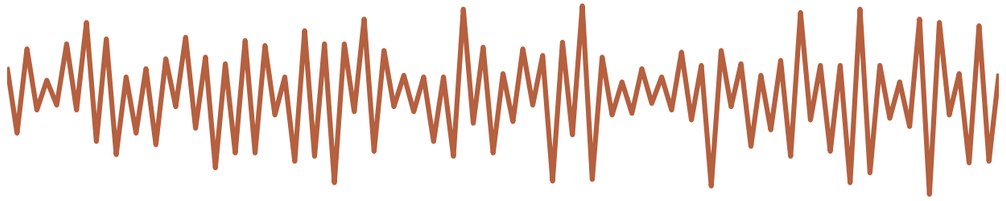
Your brain is *a song.* Your nervous system is *the radio.*

Your Check-In scored the radio. The song is the brain you were born with, and the radio decides how that song reaches you. As an ADHD coach, this is where I always start.



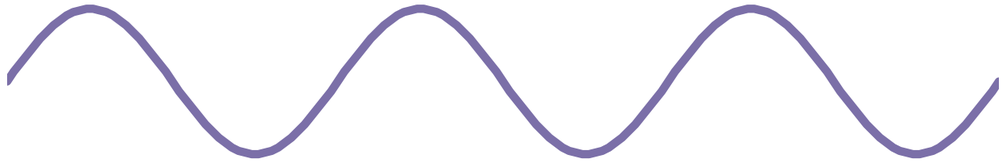
WHAT THE CHECK-IN SHOWED YOU

When the radio drifts off the station, *the song turns to static.*



Not tuned

One or more senses in red: focus, mood and sleep come through as noise.



Tuned

The same song, clear. Nothing about your brain changed.

HOW THE RADIO WORKS

A tuned radio moves between *two modes.*



Sympathetic: the gas pedal

Alert, fast, ready to act: for threat, deadlines, anything new.



Parasympathetic: the brake pedal

Slow, safe, ready to repair: for rest, digestion, sleep, connection.

THE POINT

You need both. Trouble starts when one gets stuck.

MODE 1 · THE GAS PEDAL

Constantly in sympathetic? *Ask yourself.*



Do you feel irritable over small things?



Do you reach for your phone before you open your eyes?



Do you run on coffee and skip meals?



Are your jaw clenched and your shoulders up, right now?



Are you answering messages at midnight, in yet another time zone?



Are you wired and tired at the same time?

Yes to two or more? Your heart speeds up, your breathing gets shallow, your digestion slows and your planning brain dims.

🧠 NEUROSCIENCE

The amygdala triggers the sympathetic system: **adrenaline and noradrenaline** within seconds, **cortisol** within minutes. High levels weaken the **prefrontal cortex**, the planning brain.

LeDoux, The Emotional Brain (1996) · Sapolsky 2004 · Arnsten 2009, Nat Rev Neurosci 10:410–422

AFTER A FEW YEARS

It starts to feel like your personality.

MODE 2 · THE BRAKE PEDAL

Parasympathetic: *when did you last feel…*

🎨

creative, without forcing it?

🤝

truly present with someone, phone away?

🍽️

hungry, and tasted every bite?

😴

rested, after a full night of sleep?



calm, just watching the sunset?

😌

patient, when something went wrong?

That is the brake pedal working: your heart slows, your breathing deepens, your digestion switches on, and your planning brain is back.

🧠 NEUROSCIENCE

The **vagus nerve** releases **acetylcholine** at the heart and slows it. **Heart-rate variability**, a marker of vagal tone, is higher in people who regulate their emotions well and is linked to better control of the amygdala by the **prefrontal cortex**.

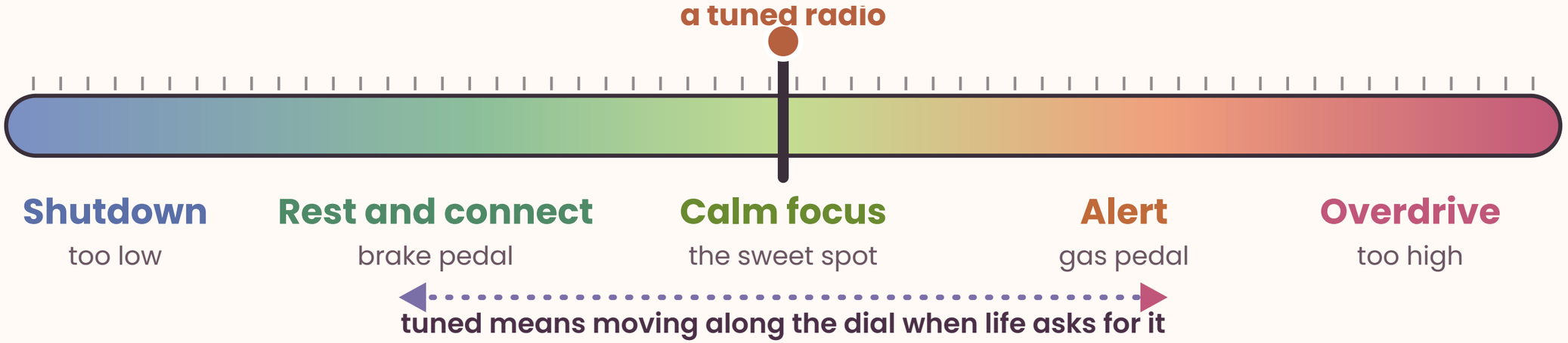
Thayer & Lane 2000, J Affect Disord 61:201-216 · Berthoud & Neuhuber 2000, Auton Neurosci 85:1-17

WHAT IT GIVES YOU

Patience, creativity, and clear decisions.

BOTH MODES TOGETHER

A tuned radio moves *along the dial.*



Stuck low: shutdown

Heavy mornings, nothing worth starting. You cancel plans and feel nothing.

Stuck high: overdrive

Irritable, wired and tired, unable to switch off.

🧠 NEUROSCIENCE

Both extremes are signs of a nervous system stuck on one station. Shutdown and freeze are described as parasympathetic states too (polyvagal theory, still debated).

Porges 2011, The Polyvagal Theory

TWO CHARACTERS IN YOUR HEAD

The alarm and *the planner.*



The alarm

THE AMYGDALA

Where: deep in the brain, an almond-sized cluster

Job: scans for threat and reacts in milliseconds

Style: fast, loud, felt in the body

When it leads: you snap, freeze, rush or go numb



The planner

THE PREFRONTAL CORTEX

Where: right behind your forehead

Job: plans, weighs, reframes and chooses

Style: slower, quieter, in words

When it leads: you pause and choose your answer

WHO ARRIVES FIRST?



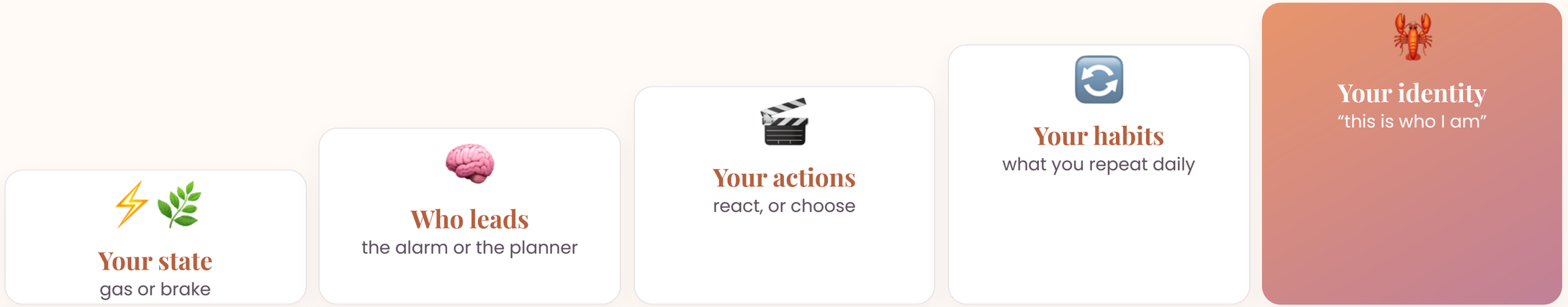
🧠 NEUROSCIENCE

The amygdala gets sensory input through a fast route via the thalamus, in about **12 milliseconds**, before the cortex has finished processing it. The **prefrontal cortex** answers more slowly, and high levels of stress hormones weaken its networks.

LeDoux, The Emotional Brain (1996) · Arnsten 2009, Nat Rev Neurosci 10:410-422

WHY THIS MATTERS

Your state decides which version of you *shows up.*



“I am not a patient person” often means “I am rarely in a state where patience is available.”

🧠 NEUROSCIENCE

Stress shifts behaviour from goal-directed to habit-driven. About 43% of everyday actions are habits repeated in the same context, and we infer who we are from what we repeatedly do.

Schwabe & Wolf 2009, J Neurosci 29:7191-7198 · Wood, Quinn & Kashy 2002, J Pers Soc Psychol 83:1281-1297 · Bem 1972, Adv Exp Soc Psychol 6:1-62

FROM THE BOOK

Your body will reject every affirmation that does not match how it feels.

THE CONNECTION

The vagus nerve is the cable between *your body and your brain.*

The longest nerve of the autonomic system: from the brainstem through the neck, the heart and the lungs down to the gut. When it is active, the heart slows, breathing deepens and digestion switches on. That is the brake pedal.

And the traffic mostly runs one way: about 80% of its signals go from the body up to the brain.

> 🧠 NEUROSCIENCE
>
> Roughly 80% of vagal fibres are **afferent**: they carry information from the organs to the brain. Only about 20% carry commands down.
>
> Berthoud & Neuhuber 2000, Autonomic Neuroscience 85:1-17



SO HOW DO WE TUNE THE RADIO?

Five doors into *the vagus nerve.*

Willpower and thinking use the 20% road down. The five senses use the 80% road up, in the language your brain listens to first.



Touch
skin, muscles, movement



Smell
nose and breath



Taste
mouth and gut



Sound
ears, rhythm, silence



Sight
eyes and light

DOOR 1 · TOUCH · MOVE, THEN PRESS

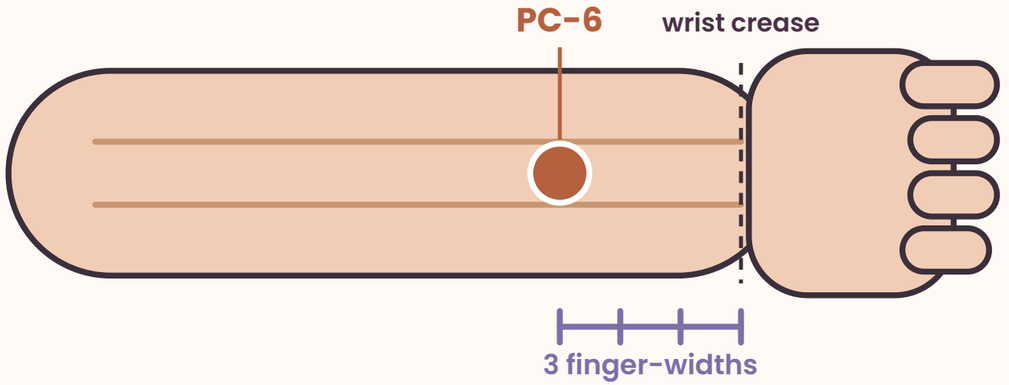
Move first. Then *press one point.*

In the Five Senses Formula, movement is the loudest volume of touch. Two minutes of shaking, dancing or fast walking discharges the stress charge held in the body.

Then one acupressure point: **Pericardium 6**, three finger-widths above the wrist crease, between the two tendons. In the book it is the point for the overwhelmed.

TRY IT NOW

Stand up, shake your arms and legs for 30 seconds. Then press PC-6 on your left wrist and breathe out slowly.



🧠 NEUROSCIENCE

Exercise raises **dopamine and norepinephrine**. PC-6 acupressure is best supported for **nausea**; the evidence for anxiety is early and mixed.

Meeusen & De Meirleir 1995, Sports Med 20:160-188 · Lee & Fan 2009, Cochrane CD003281

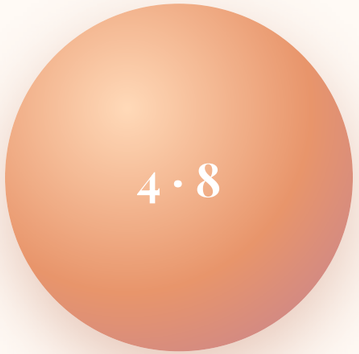
DOOR 2 · SMELL · BREATHE

Breathe out *longer than you breathe in.*

Smell is the only sense wired straight to the amygdala and the hippocampus, and your breath is the one automatic function you can steer by hand. One long exhale tells the vagus nerve to slow the heart.

TRY IT NOW, TOGETHER

In through the nose for 4, out slowly for 8, three times, following the circle.



🧠 NEUROSCIENCE

A long exhale increases **vagal activity** and slows the heart (respiratory sinus arrhythmia). Olfactory input reaches the **amygdala** and **hippocampus** without the usual thalamic relay.

Russo et al. 2017, Breathe 13:298-309 · Herz 2004, Chem Senses 29:217-224

DOOR 3 · TASTE · THE ORDER YOU EAT

Eat in this order: *fibre, protein, then carbs.*

In Morocco: start with the salads, then the tagine, and keep the bread and the pastries for last. Taste the first three bites slowly.

TRY IT AT YOUR NEXT MEAL

Eat the vegetables first, then the protein, and leave the bread for the end.

1.  **Vegetables first**
   Salad, cooked vegetables, anything green.

2.  **Protein next**
   Fish, eggs, meat, legumes, the tagine.

3.  **Carbs last**
   Bread, rice, pasta and sweets at the end.

🧠 NEUROSCIENCE

In small crossover trials, eating vegetables and protein before carbohydrate lowered the **after-meal glucose and insulin** rise compared with the reverse order. Smaller spikes mean smaller crashes, and the gut reports to the brain through the **vagus nerve**.

Shukla et al. 2015, Diabetes Care 38:e98-e99 · Shukla et al. 2017, BMJ Open Diabetes Res Care 5:e000440

The trials are small and were done in people with type 2 diabetes. The link to focus and mood is the practical application.

DOOR 4 · SOUND · SLOW RHYTHM, THEN SILENCE

Choose a slow sound, *then leave a silence.*

Sound reaches your alarm before it reaches your thoughts. Slow, steady music, around 60 beats a minute, slows breathing and heart rate. And the silence between tracks relaxes you too.

TRY IT NOW

Close your eyes for 20 seconds and listen to the room. Notice the loudest sound, then the quietest.



slow rhythm, about 60 beats a minute

then leave a silence

🧠 NEUROSCIENCE

Auditory input reaches the **amygdala** through a fast brainstem route, so tempo and volume set your alarm before you decide anything. Slow musical tempi lowered breathing and heart rate, and pauses of silence were relaxing.

Bernardi, Porta & Sleight 2006, Heart 92:445–452 · LeDoux, The Emotional Brain (1996)

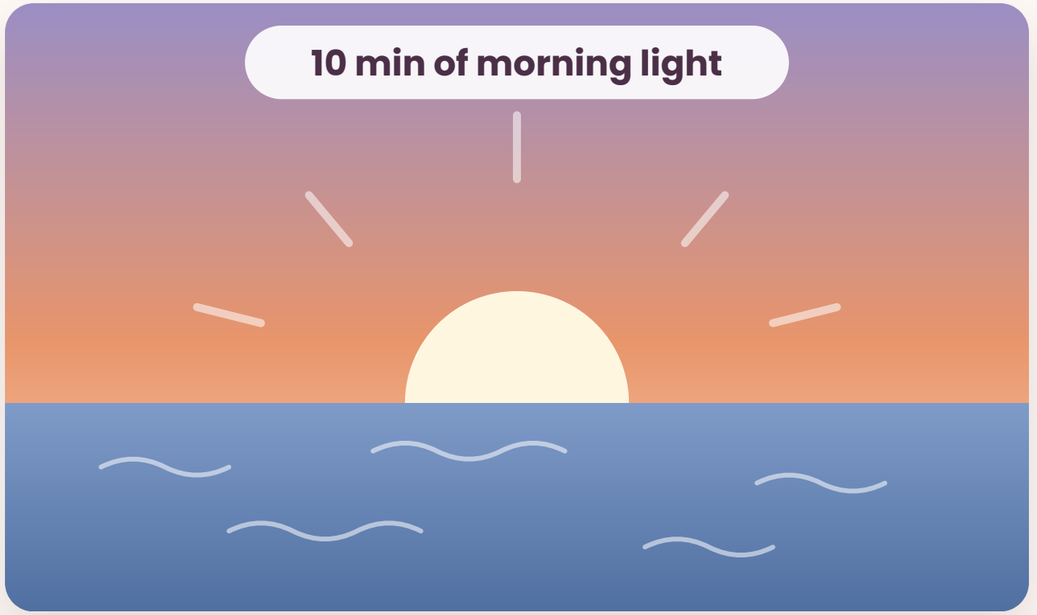
DOOR 5 · SIGHT · LIGHT AND HORIZON

Ten minutes of daylight, *before the phone.*

Special cells in your eyes read daylight and set your master clock. Morning light anchors your sleep, your energy and your mood for the next 24 hours. Then, when your eyes are tired, look at the farthest point you can see.

TOMORROW MORNING

Walk to the water with your coffee, face the light, and keep the phone in your pocket.



NEUROSCIENCE

Retinal ganglion cells containing **melanopsin** signal the **suprachiasmatic nucleus**, the master clock. A week of natural light exposure shifted people's **melatonin** timing earlier, aligning the body clock to the solar day.

Berson, Dunn & Takao 2002, Science 295:1070-1073 · Wright et al. 2013, Curr Biol 23:1554-1558

FIVE DOORS, ONE RADIO

Your *tuning kit.*



Touch

Move, then press PC-6



Smell

Breathe out longer, 4 in, 8 out



Taste

Vegetables, protein, carbs last



Sound

A slow track, then silence



Sight

Morning light, then the horizon

FROM THE BOOK

One sense regulates. Two shift your state. Three change your baseline.

THE KEY TAKEAWAY

You cannot think your way into a new identity *from a dysregulated nervous system.*

Regulation comes first. It starts in the body, in the only language your nervous system understands: sensation.

THE ORDER

Regulate first. *Then build.*

1

Regulate

The body first, through the five senses: touch, smell, taste, sound, sight.

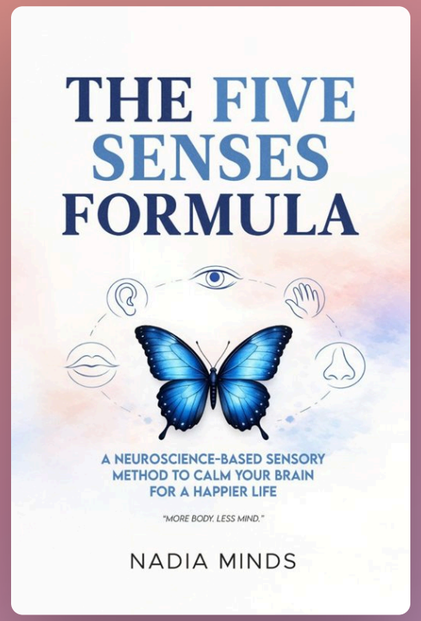
2

Build

Your habits, your work and your identity, from a calm system.

CONTINUE THE WORK

Finish your Check-In. *Come and find me.*



The book

Your Check-In

@nadiaminds

I am here all week. Tell me which sense was your red one.